Overhearing Agents

What are they?

- Conversational agents: presented as a chatbot

- But it's not always practical to chat with an LLM!

- Overhearing agents: "listen in" to human-human conversations or activities

- Suggest help from the background

- Building on top of Kani + ReDel: delegate generating suggestions to sub-agents for real-time performance

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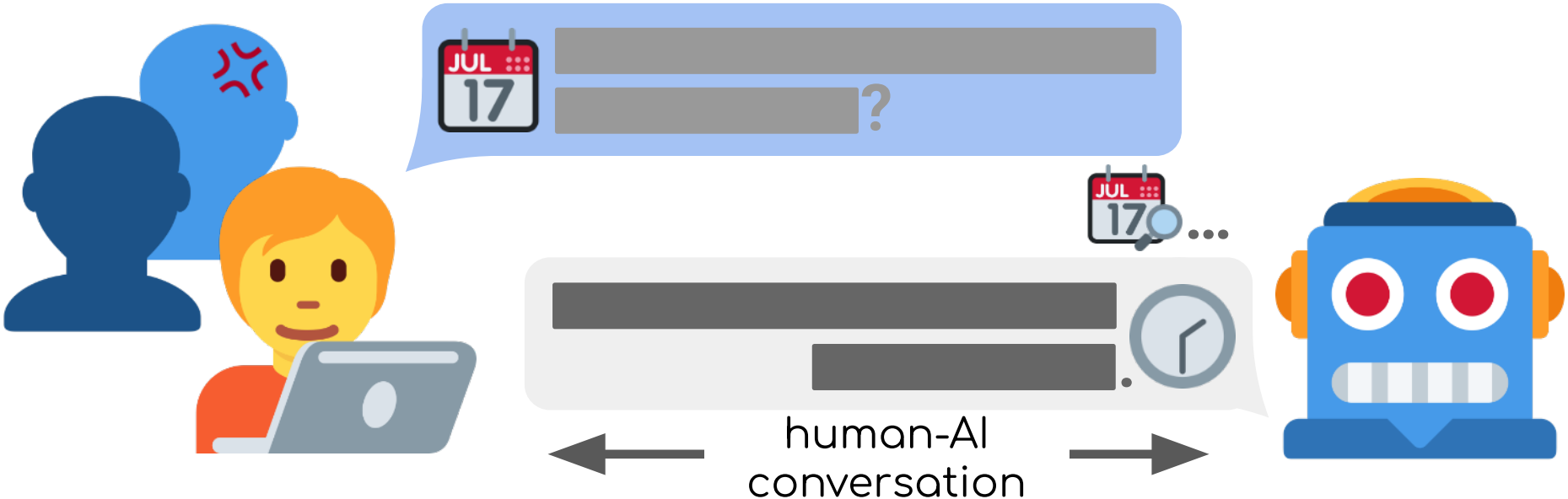
Conversational Agents



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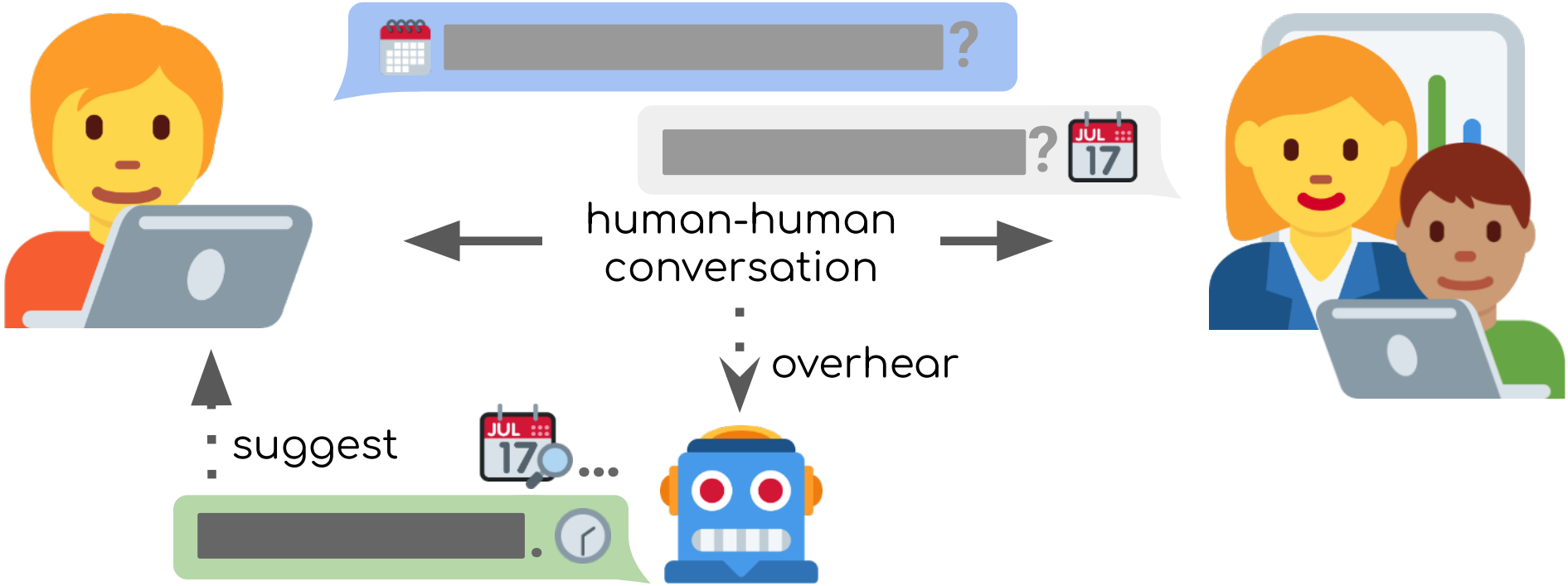

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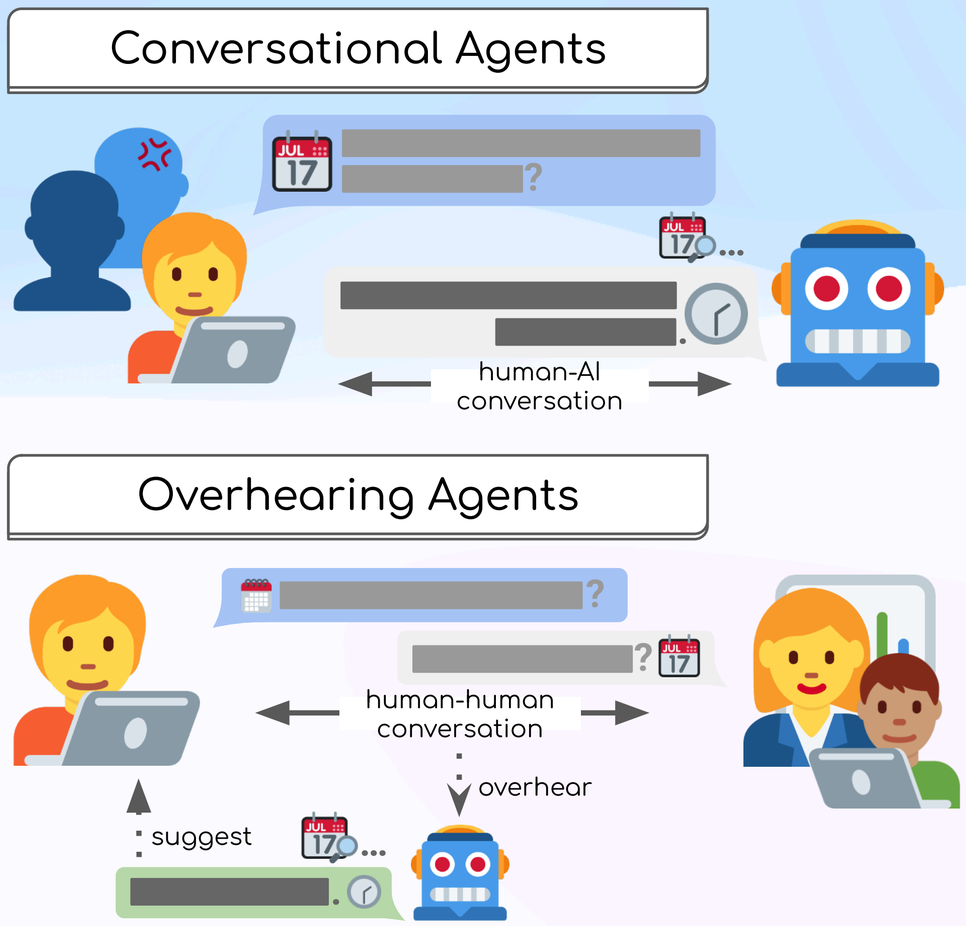

Overhearing Agents

Dimensions of Overhearing

- First: survey NLP + HCI papers to create a grounded taxonomy of overhearing

	Dimension	Value	Example(s)
User Interaction	Initiative	Always Active	Always-listening voice assistants (Tabassum et al. 2019; Zargham et al. 2022)
		User-Initiated	Wordcraft (Yuan et al. 2022)
		Post-Hoc Analysis	More to Meetings (McGregor and Tang 2017)
		Rule-Based	Apple Intelligence (Apple 2025)
	Input Modality	Audio	Bardo (Padovani, Ferreira, and Lelis 2017), LlamaPIE (Chen et al. 2025)
		Text	Code "Copilots" (Barke, James, and Polikarpova 2023)
		Video	EgoExo4D (Grauman et al. 2024)
	Interfaces	Web and Desktop	Proactive Search (Andolina et al. 2018), ProactiveAgent (Lu et al. 2024)
		Wearable Devices	LlamaPIE (Chen et al. 2025), Meta smart glasses (Meta 2024)
		Smart Home	Home voice assistants (Tabassum et al. 2019; Zargham et al. 2022; Hwang et al. 2023)
System Design	State	Read-Only	Proactive Search (Andolina et al. 2018)
		Read-Write	More to Meetings (McGregor and Tang 2017)
	Timeliness	Real-Time	Bardo (Padovani, Ferreira, and Lelis 2017)
		Asynchronous	ReDel (Zhu, Dugan, and Callison-Burch 2024)
	Interactivity	Foreground	Most overhearing agents
		Background	AI agent memory (Park et al. 2023), DocPrompting (Zhou et al. 2023)